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Making Political Representation in Territories of the City: The Role of *Mandatos* in São Paulo

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Abstract

Recent literature has advanced our understanding of local politics and electoral mobilization, focusing on political relationships between politicians and voters and the roles of political brokers. Drawing from ethnographic research on local councilors and their political staff in São Paulo, Brazil, this article introduces a critical contribution: the concept of *mandatos*. These are networks of actors linked by partisan, political, professional, and personal ties, which help mobilize support for politicians. By bridging formal institutions and informal practices, *mandatos* transform specific urban territories into constituencies. Their structure and actions transcend individual brokers and mediate larger entities, such as political parties, legislative bodies, and executive agencies, as well as smaller local groups and voters. While brokers play a key role, *mandatos* are more complex and dynamic than the hierarchical view of brokers and politicians suggests. This article invites scholars to rethink how we understand local representation and electoral networks.

Keywords

political representation, councilors, brokers, *mandatos*, São Paulo

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Introduction

The connections between representatives and voters in democracies were classically considered by political science to be an automatic product of the rational calculus of politicians, parties, and voters (Downs 1957). Political intermediation involving personalized exchanges would lead to political machines, clientelism, and patronage, violating representative politics. In traditional interpretations, these practices would naturally disappear as democracies matured (Scott 1977). Concerned with the characteristics of the third wave of democracies, comparative studies have sustained they did not disappear, something confirmed by the subsequent agenda of investigations about clientelist practices, mainly in the Global South. More recent contributions have better defined those practices (Stokes et al. 2013), often highlighting their negative consequences (Stokes 2005), which led to a prolific agenda about the mobilization of voters on the ground, focused on individual and organizational actors, especially brokers, and their political exchanges and strategies (Auerbach 2017; Bussell 2019; Dosek 2024; Holland and Palmer Rubin 2015; Hurtado 2018; Zarazaga 2014).

This article adds an essential piece to this puzzle, broader than brokers and types of political exchange. Elaborating theoretically on the native concept of *mandatos* in Brazil, we show the importance of political mobilization of mid-size structures that embed brokers and politicians. *Mandatos* aim at creating and expanding political support for a politician or political group by continuously reaching and mobilizing citizens. They include politicians, their formal staff, and other informally connected actors in networks of political mobilization that link to voters in the territory. *Mandatos* bridge formal institutions (such as parties, legislative bodies, and executive agencies) with informal groups (such as local associations) and voters in society. By doing so, they systematically connect the local Council with the city's territories, parties with voters, and actively build constituencies. The focus on these structures, therefore, complements and better integrates several findings from previous studies concentrated on individual actors and on types of political exchange.

Considering a few widely used concepts such as political machines, clientelism, and political work, conceptual disclaimers are important to situate the reader. While these elements will be better further developed in the first section, we anticipate general clarifications in the following lines. Political machines are organized and vertical structures of political mobilization with a clear command chain that leads to a boss. They are often entrenched in formal institutions and associated with patronage and spoil systems (Wolfinger 1972). *Mandatos*, differently, are much less hierarchical and coherent and more decentralized. A great part of this is explained by the

intense local competition and the rules for councilors' elections, which use proportional representation at large in very large districts. Therefore, although each *mandato* is attached to one politician, they are not a boss (in the sense used in the political machine) and rarely exercise a strong vertical command. Moreover, *mandatos* face competition within and even oppose each other within the same party (and between parties) in quite competitive political environments. This differs from what Dosek (2023) describes as the equipo politico or political team. In Paraguay's case, the author describes a typically pyramidal organizational structure within each party with several layers. The candidate (or group of candidates) is at the top of the pyramid during a campaign. Alongside them is a small team of trusted individuals (usually candidates for lower positions), long-time leaders, and friends, ranging from about 10 to 15 people or up to 30 to 40, depending on the type of candidacy. Below them is a layer of neighborhood or geographic area leaders. These leaders are often elected officials from the (sub-)sections or (sub-)committees responsible for these sectors or areas. They are supported by networks of brokers, which may have one or two levels, with the second case including brokers of brokers or coordinators. These operators, with their brokers, are often leaders of social organizations or neighborhood commissions. The grassroots brokers are the neighborhood residents or heads of large families. One of the politicians illustrates this organizational structure as follows: "It's the spiral… [We are] the main team, the core, and then it expands, expands, until in the end, it's more than 1,400 of us."

Mandato's mid-level participants, for example, may migrate between *mandatos*, taking with them the votes they mobilize on the ground. They are certainly part of the machines of political parties for political mobilization, although far from political machines in the classic sense of the literature.

Another common concept worth mentioning is political work, or "*trabalho político*" in Portuguese or the better known "*trabajo politico*" in Spanish. Political work is a regular work associated with certain careers targeted to acquire political support for someone. It is a native concept in our case and other places in Latin America (Hurtado 2018). Some activities of the *trabalho político* include constituency service, while others do not. The idea of political work includes several types of activities and does not try to differentiate between types of political exchanges (clientelist, pork barrel, programmatic, etc.). It is multidimensional and involves the organization of daily lives of neighborhoods, the production of public goods, and the embeddedness of these elements in local networks of relations (Hurtado 2018). An important part of what happens in *mandatos* in São Paulo is indeed political work. This may include channeling petitions from local organizations to the Council (or the Executive branch), providing information about public programs and policies to the population, and helping to deliver public goods,

among many other activities. However, the idea of *mandatos* goes beyond the activities themselves and defines and analytically characterizes the interconnected political actors, relations, and practices around and behind those actions.

By doing "political work," actors within the *mandatos* build constituencies through the political mobilization of citizens/voters in the territory and associate them with a particular politician or political group (and party). They are, however, internally diverse, which introduces complexity to collective action and contributes to how political representation is understood. We argue that an exclusive focus on brokers (and their types) or types of political exchange misses the entanglements and conflicts present in political mobilization and exaggerates its hierarchical structure, which has consequences for how we understand political representation.

This leads us to clientelism, the most used concept to characterize political mobilization in Latin America. Although it's a polysemic word, more thorough definitions consider it as a political grammar that involves personalized, contingent, and monitored political exchanges of benefits (or their promise) for votes (Stokes et al. 2013). The practices that happen within a *mandato* may involve clientelistic relationships, although they may also include the distribution of pork barrel, the performance of constituency services, and the construction and mobilization of partisan programmatic ties. More extreme practices discussed by the literature such as vote buying and coercion (Dosek 2024) are not present in our case or tend to be very peripheral. In this article, we are less interested in discussing the nature of political ties than in describing and analyzing the composition, features, and practices of the local political mobilization structures we call *mandatos*.

Similarly, although *mandatos* incorporate brokers as a crucial feature, their dynamics are more significant than the sole aggregation of brokers and elected politicians, since they are potentially contentious and even incongruent as a collective. Explaining the effects of *mandatos* in the politics of a large-scale city leads us to a better understanding of how territorial political mobilization is built and operated more broadly. This is the focus of the article.

The literal translation into English for *mandato* would be the word "mandate," as "term in office." However, a *mandato* does not refer to an incumbency period (in fact, it is not even bounded by it) and also includes several actors external to the local parliamentary staff and their informal ties. *Mandato* is what people who operate politics in the cities' territories call the basic units of political mobilization of one politician during and between elections. A *mandato* can be organized around a politician who holds formal parliamentary offices, but also around a politician who lost a seat and plans to win it back. Holding together these collective action units increases their chances of being re-elected or of returning to power. The

mandatos also involve representatives (and candidates for seats) at other federation levels (state and federal) who belong to the same political group. In this case, the *mandatos* of these politicians are superposed and mingled in the interest of resource sharing and economies of scale, since they do not compete for the same seats. *Mandatos* are frequently embedded in political party structures, integrating them vertically (Hoyler and Marques 2023), and are always grounded in the territory, where the mobilization of voters happens. For this reason, city councilors are crucial for their creation and operation.

In large Brazilian cities, the centrality of these mid-sized structures is vital because of the size of electoral districts in existing electoral rules. Elections in Brazil adopt large multi-member electoral districts. This means that a candidate – not previously ordered in a party list – can be voted by any citizen within the whole municipality. In small cities, the district is closer to the constituency, similar to single-member district systems. But in large municipalities, such as São Paulo, a politician must connect with voters and deliver pork barrel or constituency services in a territory of more than 1.5 million km² and 12 million inhabitants. The effect of scale is even more pronounced for state and national elections since the districts in those cases coincide with whole states (provinces). Therefore, large districts demand structures that mobilize politically while building constituencies, informally delimited in the territory. This is done through *mandatos* in Brazil and this article is dedicated to explaining how they operate.

The article builds on three basic assumptions. Firstly, local politics is not considered merely a scale, an institutional or jurisdictional perimeter inside which votes are aggregated, but a specific subject considering its spatiality. Secondly, we go beyond the electoral moment and consider the whole period of incumbency since this explains an essential part of how city councilors win elections. Thirdly, we consider representation is built by political mobilization, jointly with constituencies. In this sense, the representational link is not something simply given for those who win elections, but socially constructed by constant political mobilization on the ground.

The article is structured in four sections, in addition to this introduction and the conclusion. The first section presents a theoretical overview of where the discussion about *mandatos* can be localized and details how the research was conducted methodologically. The second section describes our findings, beginning with an explanation of the functioning of *mandatos* and their connections to formal institutions, parties, and their members. In the third section, we discuss how a political territory and probable constituency is built within much broader districts in the city and how space matters to *mandatos*. The fourth section discusses incongruencies within a *mandato* through an example of a housing public–private partnership, suggesting a different approach to the discussion of representation brought by the representative turn literature.

Localizing Local Politics and *Mandatos* Conceptually

Considering the well-known importance of institutional rules for various key features of political systems, it is essential to begin with some details about Brazilian institutions. Since the most recent return to democracy, the country adopts a single institutional format of mayor-Council for the governments of all 5,570 municipalities. Direct elections are held every 4 years to choose mayors and councilors (with indefinite reelection). Councilors are elected under proportional open list rules in at-large districts. It is widely known that these electoral rules induce intense party fragmentation, personal vote, and interparty competition, with a strong impact on the daily workings of local politics and some of the features we will see in *mandatos*.

Local politics in Latin America (and Brazil) is typically studied through two main streams of inquiry. As in other countries, many studies explore the so-called electoral connection and its effects on legislative production, parties, and the political system more broadly. Many facets of the electoral connection have been studied in and about Brazil. Several studies investigated patterns of coattail and inverse coattail effects (Ames 1994; Samuels 2000), in the allocation of bills (Amorim Neto and Santos 2003) and budget amendments to specific so-called clienteles (Firpo, Ponczek and Sanfelice 2015). Answering this same debate, other studies have focused on local chambers and councilors beyond formal law-making and incorporating other practices (D'Ávila, Cerqueira Lima and Jorge 2014; Hoyler 2022; Rocha e Silva 2017).

A second stream of inquiry analyzes distributive politics, mainly centered around clientelism. The concept was developed to describe the relationship between politicians and voters in the first decades of the 20th century, mostly in rural conditions with very low access to policies, authoritarian environments, and strong political control over voters, including the absence of an official ballot and open voting, among other problems for electoral freedom (Leal 2012 [1948]). In those conditions, poor voters were passive recipients of aid in electoral times, targeted by intermediaries operating in their neighborhoods (Auerbach 2017).

Some classic interpretations even saw an evolutionist trail between clientelism and political machines, with fully democratic politics at the end of the continuum (Scott 1969). Political machines controlled political mobilization in large U.S. cities during the expansion of suffrage between the end of the 19th century and the first decades of the 20th century. Political machines were vertical structures of political mobilization dedicated to the mobilization of poor voters, at the same time pillaging resources from public offices and budgets. They were considered one of the most serious challenges for U.S. democracy (Bryce 1995 [1889]), leading to the Urban Reform Movement and the adoption of institutional changes in the organization of local

governments (Stewart 1950). By mid-20th century, they were seriously reduced in prevalence and became less durable and weaker in structure, although they did not disappear (Wolfinger 1972). Parties continue to use machine politics, but this shouldn't be confused with political machines, which depend on vertical organizations with clear command, something quite rare in U.S. cities today.

In the case of clientelism, similarly, the political conditions that surrounded rural clientelism changed substantially through time. In Brazil, but also many other countries, social and political transformations such as urbanization, public policy expansion, and the construction of stronger institutions —national electoral courts, secret voting (and recently electronic voting), stricter rules for electoral financing, among others (Limongi 2015)— changed completely the control over voters and the contingency of benefits. Still, some recent studies continue to point out similar practices, especially in rural areas (Ansell 2018; Nichter 2018) with normative consequences (Stokes 2005). In this case, studies "tend to view machine politics and the hierarchies of brokers who enable it from a topdown, party-centered perspective" (Auerbach 2017, p. 1), predominantly during elections.

Most international debates, however, have moved towards making clearer and defining the phenomenon under contemporary conditions—urban, democratic, competitive, and institutionalized. This effort starts with Eulau and Karps (1977)'s classic separation between (i) policy representativeness (following the constituency's position), (ii) service representativeness (ensuring benefits for the constituency), (iii) allocation responsiveness (providing particularized benefits), and iv. symbolic responsiveness, or public gestures (creating trust and support). Kitschelt and Wilkinson (2007) and Stokes et al. (2013) added further conceptual clarity to the field of differentiating pork barrel—when public or club goods are delivered to a constituency without individualization or monitoring—from clientelism, personalized contingent political exchanges of goods and services for votes, monitored by brokers.

Precision in the definition of brokers and their actions became one of the most important analytical frontiers following Stokes et al. (2013). Weitz-Shapiro (2014) showed the variation of the phenomena within Argentina; Dosek (2024) explained their roles in local caudillos resilience in Chile, Paraguay, and Peru; and Koster (2012) found a broker in Brazil working for two candidates at the same time. Strong evidence that the practices of brokers channel many things beyond clientelism came with the idea of "problem-solving", found in Argentina by Auyero (2000) and Zarazaga (2014), in Uruguay by Alvarez Rivadulla (2012), in Mexico by Hagene (2015), in Brazil by Koster (2012), and in Paraguay by Dosek (2023). Results in the same direction were found by Auerbach (2016) and Bussell (2019) for India. Zarazaga (2014) presented compelling evidence that

brokers multitask, connect quite intensely with parties, and perform essential executive governance functions once their party is in power. Bussell added that in the Indian case, brokers also perform constituency services, practices previously discussed in Europe and the United States (Cain, Ferejohn and Fiorina 1984), although not as much to understand the Global South. More recently, the idea of political work has been complementing the interpretation of these practices in Latin America. For Hurtado (2018), "*trabajo político*" is defined by people who professionally live from politics as work, performing sets of actions oriented to obtain political support for a politician, a party, or a cause. This includes organizing the daily lives of communities and enabling the production and access of public goods.

The dubious logic behind brokers' actions was also considered by several authors. Koster (2012) found a broker in Recife campaigning for two candidates at the same time, and Merry (2006) showed the position of brokers implies various clients and bosses, leading to accusations of "double-dealing." Holland and Palmer-Rubin (2015) identified what would be a specific type of brokers, the organizational ones, leaders of associations who act to represent the interests of these associations and may imply disloyalty to the politician who hired them. James (2011), finally, has recognized that brokers bring groups together, leaving room for difference, their own "independent" position, and their own "room for maneuver."

While most of the literature considers individual brokers, Auerbach (2017) and Holland and Palmer-Rubin (2015) showed that brokerage roles may also be performed by neighborhood organizations in India and Latin America, respectively. In a similar direction, the role of local networks in accessing policies and in bridging party mobilization has been discussed in several places, such as in Africa (Paller 2015), Latin America (Hurtado 2018), Argentina (Auyero 2000), Uruguay (Alvarez Rivadulla 2012), Brazil (Hoyler and Marques 2023), and India (Auerbach 2016 and 2017; Bussell 2019). In a similar direction, Lachi (2008) discussed clientele communities in Paraguay based on native closed support communities. Finally, authors such as Kuschnir (2000), Rocha e Silva (2017), D'Ávila, Cerqueira Lima and Jorge (2014), Rocha (2023) and Hoyler and Marques (2023) have discussed councilors and their political mobilization networks in recent Brazil, highlighting the importance of the political work done by political advisors.

Several of these elements come together in *mandatos*, as we will develop extensively in the next section. These are mid-level structures composed of several connected actors, including politicians and their brokers of different types—formal aids, but also many other people with local mobilization capacity. All these actors perform political work for a certain politician, but some coordinate activities, while others implement mobilization directly. Some activities may be classified as clientelism, while many others as constituency

services, pork barrel, programmatic, and partisan-driven actions. The composition of the presence of these distributive practices probably varies by context and city by the degree of political competition and considering the "thickness" of civil society, but only comparative research focused on this could make this argument a refined one. Brokers, additionally, occupy multiple positions, with split loyalties between local associations, party groups, and politicians. Considering that all this depends on trust, political work is continuous, and not just during elections. *Mandatos* coexist, compete, and overlap within parties. Therefore, considering the degree of competition and the lack of a clear hierarchical structure, *mandatos* are quite far from political machines, although they certainly are part of the structures of political mobilization developed and maintained by parties.

This article was built from part of the analysis of a PhD research that began in 2018 with a genuine and broad curiosity to understand what councilors do and how they do it (Hoyler 2022). While the available theory allowed the understanding of several features of legislative work, it did not explain several elements associated with the organization of councilor's staff/politician's team, including their internal disputes, and the very use and meaning of the concept of *mandato*, so frequently used on the ground. This led to a reorientation of the research, concentrating attention on what came directly from the field.

Methodologically, this led to the use of ethnography, incorporating reflexivity, interdisciplinarity, and plurality (Crewe 2021). The use of ethnographic methods is not very common in political science. Joseph and Ayuero's (2007) literature review illustrates this point: among almost 1,000 articles published over 10 years (1996–2005) in the *American Journal of Political Science* and the *American Political Science Review*, the authors found only one that relied on ethnography as a way of producing research information. This is curious, as ethnographies have long fueled the field of political science, at least since Fenno (1977)'s classic study of U.S. Congress. The discussion of political machines in U.S. cities was also abundantly fed by ethnographies that sought to understand the intricacies of power in cities (as in Rakove 1975). This, however, has apparently been lost between the 1960s and 2000s, with a more recent revival of the use of the method.

The research started by following the daily life of the City Council of São Paulo in the space where advisors met to watch and assist in Plenary Sessions and also observing other institutional gatherings, such as Committees. The behavior and discourse of councilors in the Plenary, often referring to the territories in which they worked, began to show that a broader focus was needed. The organization of each councilor's staff and daily work also raised obvious concerns. If a councilor's office could hire 18 advisors, where were they? Not a single office had desks for all those people if they decided to show up to

work simultaneously. The constant answer was that "they are in the streets." Understanding what "being in the streets" meant became crucial.

It also became clear that some of these advisors were more important than others, at least in the organization of what was happening outside the Council. Therefore, between 2018 and 2022, the research chose two councilors to focus the study, one from a center-right and another one from a center-left party, to allow the understanding of the generality of the patterns. Among the staffs of each of the two councilors, the research chose one broker with a central political role. From this point on, the research followed countless daily activities of these brokers and their relational networks during 3 years. This was done in person and then with WhatsApp follow-ups during the pandemic, although the 2022 elections were also followed in person. The whole research included three electoral periods, but the fieldwork covered one municipal (2020) and one federal/state election (2002). Due to space restrictions, this article only deals with empirical cases from the center-right councilor. However, the patterns and practices are quite similar, and what we will report is also informed by the broader research.

The research also uses what Herzog and Zacka (2019) called ethnographic sensibility to interpret the 81 interviews with one mayor, submayors, municipal secretaries and their chiefs of staff, state and federal representatives, councilors, bureaucrats (from the executive and the Council), journalists, and brokers of different types and parties (Hoyler 2022). This helped to triangulate information and to produce more comprehensive statements. In total, the research interviewed and followed interlocutors from eight parties (wide ideological range), considering their political affiliation in 2017. Parties' names, places, and interlocutors' identification are omitted throughout the text and mentioned only when the information comes from public documents or literature. Through the article, we cite one Councilor, Paulo; two of his macro brokers, Antonio and Ines; and one micro broker, Capitão, linked to Antonio. All these names are fictional.

Mandatos as Brokerage Structures and Their Connection with Parties

We must start by specifying more precisely what is a *mandato*, distinguishing it from the councilor's offices. The latter is institutionally defined by the legal structure of recruitment and payment of staff by the City Council and corresponds to a physical space where they work inside the Council. A *mandato* is used both to refer to the period of incumbency (four years) and also concerns the group of people who do political work for a councilor, something defined natively as a "space of action," "group," "political project," and "instrument" according to how each one experiences the everyday life of politics.

We define *mandato* as a set of connected actors aiming to produce and expand political support for a councilor (or someone who tries to regain office) with different levels of mutual engagement held together through formal and informal agreements and political and professional (sometimes friendship) ties. By mobilizing support for a politician, it actively builds constituencies, although many incongruencies may arise while bridging parties, formal institutions, and informal practices on specific territories of the city. This informal mid-level structure produces coordination and mediates the connections between larger structures (as parties, legislative bodies, and executive agencies) and small groups in society (as local associations). They are not organizations, and certainly not formal entities, although they partially overlap with the representatives' staffs. They are usually active and entrenched in specific territories, especially in poor neighborhoods, and many of their participants (especially the ones at the lower tiers of the network) are community leaders.

Each *mandato* is centered on a politician and his/her official staff together with several other staff informally connected to the *mandato*. The main politician in a *mandato* is someone who was elected and holds a position in the local council, the state assembly, and the national Congress, but may also be someone who lost the previous election and plans to regain a post. Frequently, other politicians of the same political group within the party participate in a *mandato* or just merge their *mandatos* cooperating during elections. This usually happens because they hold offices at different levels—federal, state, and local—but conflicts may arise when competition at the same level comes into the picture. This happens, for example, when someone loses a seat at a higher level and decides to go back and try to be elected in an office of a different level. These informal mid-level structures help to coordinate vertically the parties and the political system more broadly (Hoyler and Marques 2023).

They include formally paid staff and others that are paid through some informal (and sometimes illegal) manner, but also others who are not paid or just paid on specific occasions, although hope to become regularly paid once they go up the brokers' ladder. Therefore, *mandatos* are directly funded by the local Council's budget, since many receive regular salaries as advisors. However, in many cities, there is a limitation on the number of staff that can be formally hired, which creates difficulties for the territorial reach that councilors need to acquire in large cities. Therefore, *mandatos* are also heavily funded by informal (and illegal) transfers of parts of staff's salaries to other participants of the *mandato*. This is certainly the case when the councilor loses the election and must rely on the informal support of another councilor or state representative's political group to keep his own group united and ready to compete in the next election. Illegal donations from local businessmen also contribute to funding this whole structure.

Although traditionally the budget amount for each councilor was fixed, they could decide how to allocate it internally. Since 2016, a new municipal regulation has limited the total amount of staff. It intended to organize political competition by creating a standard configuration. However, it was created with a normative view of how things should happen, not considering how political work (*trabalho politico*) was done. Currently, in the case of São Paulo, while only 18 advisors can be formally hired, the number of informal advisors can get to 50 or more than 100, depending also on the availability of resources (including money from corruption in some cases). Through these informal transfers, formal staff hand over part of their salary to those not officially hired, enabling them to multiply the number of people working in a *mandato*. Whether formally hired or not, all of them do the *political work* as brokers.

Brokerage Structure

> I started by participating in everything that happened in the area: public hearings, facilities councils, […], everything there was, there I would be. I still do, but now I have started putting other local leaders there and even helping them to be elected [in local councils]. That's how I started to meet local leaders and go into poorer neighborhoods. As time went by, I got to know more families got involved with them… poor people have much more demand, so keeping in touch is easy!

This paragraph, with direct citation of Antonio, could pretty much sum up how to become a broker in São Paulo.

Among the participants of *mandatos*, brokers are central actors. They have leadership skills and an interest in acting politically. Along with being part of a *mandato*, they are generally part of other spheres of social and political life, including participatory councils, social movements, neighborhood associations, bureaucracies, etc., intertwining with instances of public authority. They are valued for these multiple positionalities, since belonging to various bodies creates and increases brokers' ties with social groups and individuals. This, however, may also create tensions between the various groups to which they belong. After all, as a member of the *mandato*, interests may point in one direction, while as a member of one of these bodies, they may point in another. This also applies to councilors, as they have groups to which they are more attached. Therefore, although brokers serve the purpose of forming and expanding constituencies, their practices can also make this plan more difficult, leading to constant negotiations and conflicts within *mandatos*.

We differentiate brokers as macro- and microbrokers, considering their ties with the *mandato*, their political skills, and the size of their potential influence over votes. While an advisor is an empirical category associated with a formal position in the City Council, macro- and microbrokers are analytical categories that indicate roles and practices in the structure. These are not native terms, and they are both called by Portuguese terms such as *assessores*, *mobilizadores*, and *lideranças*, referencing activities they might perform. "I'm nothing without my local leaders" and "I strengthen my local leaders"[1] are phrases we often hear from macrobrokers.

Taking councilors as starting points, macrobrokers are directly linked to them (many employed as staff), while microbrokers are linked to councilors by secondary ties. Microbrokers are connected to voters daily and are usually embedded in the territory. Many of them are community organizers, local businessmen, and social project leaders. Therefore, below microbrokers are usually voters, although many campaign footsoldiers are hired and answer to them during electoral periods. In an imperfect analogy with public policy structures, we could say that microbrokers resemble street-level bureaucrats, who have a direct link to citizens, while macrobrokers are similar to street-level managers, who control and supervise their work but do not have direct contact with beneficiaries (Lipsky 1980).

The size of the mobilization network varies according to factors such as years of incumbency—as more people tend to be mobilized and connected to the mandato as a function of time—and can include the capacity of the *mandato* to raise money through corruption practices, which allow hiring more people. It is difficult to establish an average of microbrokers and macrobrokers per *mandato*, since they often try to portray their connections as wider than they are to show they do the political work right. This research is still to be done systematically. During elections, economic variations are quite huge among *mandatos* as well. Since there is no limit to how expensive a campaign can be if we include corruption, let's consider a middle-cost campaign as an example of how the mobilization network is enlarged during the electoral period.

For councilor's Paulo's term, the 2020 municipal election had fewer financial resources compared to previous years, but according to their brokers, they could still "be in the race." With the amount of R$ 55,000 (approx. US$ 9,000.00) allocated to Antonio by the campaign management, he hired 146 people: 15 people to work for 45 days before the election for a salary of R $ 1,500.00 (approx. US$ 248); 51 other people to work for 15 days before the election for R$ 500.00 (approx. US$ 80); and 80 more people to work on the election day for R$ 100.00 (approx. US$ 17) Since the budget didn't match, he took R$ 1,000.00 (approx. US$ 165) out of his pocket to cover the difference, believing it would make a difference to win the elections and to maintain his job.

Ideally, councilors look for macrobrokers who are strongly linked to the *mandato*, demonstrating a commitment to the councilor's political project —although, as we will see, brokers have an agenda of their own. Macrobrokers, on their part, look for microbrokers with the same profile but centered in communities that might be scattered around the city, although there are advantages to forming clusters. Still, all this depends on the political alliances and dynamics of brokers' entries and exits from the *mandato*. Most microbrokers want to become macrobrokers, and some of the latter have the hope to become councilors sometime in the future.

Ties with microbrokers are created and maintained through the circulation of macrobrokers through space. Not often, though, do brokers manage to bring councilors to places they have connections with. This is due to geographical distances, the multiplicity of territories, and councilors' many legislative tasks within the Council. Having the councilor visit a particular community brings prestige to the macro- and the microbroker. Therefore, councilor's schedule is disputed among brokers inside the same *mandato*. Councilors' visits usually happen during campaigns and delivery of some benefit to the community in question and when the Executive branch is present at a given event, often leading potential voters to say "they only come during elections." This dynamic is reproduced from macro- to microbrokers on a smaller scale. Microbrokers are expected to identify and solve issues of low complexity and call the macrobrokers when necessary, always associating the problem-solving with the councilor and the *mandato*.

These strategies of credit claiming happen throughout the whole period of incumbency, and not in direct exchange for votes although votes are expected. Solving problems means identifying demands and sometimes activating the Executive branch to solve them, from fixing streetlights or collecting rubbish to more complex issues such as providing land regularization. The Executive branch does not have enough structure to root on the ground in large cities, and when it does, it is through the intermediation of brokers. This political work (Hurtado 2018) usually mobilizes formal instruments such as budget amendments or written petitions. The former may be understood as pork barrel, while the latter resembles constituency services (Bussell 2019). Very rarely our cases on the field indicated severe practices such as the extortion and intimidation found by Dosek (2024) in Paraguay, regardless of the presence of a very strong criminal organization in poor neighborhoods.[2] However, the presence of individualized conditional and monitored exchanges, practices that the literature classifies as clientelism (Nichter 2018; Stokes et al. 2013), tends to be rare. This is for sure influenced by the wide access to services even in poor areas (although with lower quality) and the intense political competition of São Paulo elections. Only

further research, comparative with other contexts and cities, may suggest what organizes the variability of these practices.

Mandatos and Parties

Concerning parties, *mandatos* operate by aggregating interests and organizing intra-party competition and cooperation (Hoyler and Marques 2023). Since no candidate can be voted for if not enlisted by a party, parties are essential in the electoral arena as channels for recruiting people, enabling political careers, linking resources, establishing partnerships, and making strategic decisions regarding positioning with other parties. However, intra-party life and negotiations are animated mainly through alliances between *mandatos* that are operated at a multi-scale level—between councilors and state/federal representatives through informal alliances connecting candidates of different levels involving varying degrees of support in the same election with the expectation of later reciprocation. Through these alliances, candidates share costs, staff, and campaign resources. If candidates lose the election, they can allocate some of their brokers in someone else's *mandato* to keep in touch with their constituencies.

Alliances between mandates within parties are not automatic; rather, they are actively built in an intra-party competitive environment. This means that the result of such alliances is not a unified and integrated structure, as suggested by Dosek (2023, p. 623). In examining the case of Paraguay, the author describes the equipo político as a typically pyramidal organizational structure within each party, consisting of several layers. According to Dosek, the candidate (or group of candidates) is at the top of the pyramid during a campaign. Alongside them is a small team of trusted individuals (usually candidates for lower positions), long-time leaders, and friends, typically numbering from 10 to 15 people or up to 30 to 40, depending on the type of candidacy. Below them is a layer of neighborhood or geographic area leaders. These leaders are often elected officials from the (sub-)sections or (sub-)committees responsible for these sectors or areas. They are supported by networks of brokers, which may have one or two levels, with the second case involving brokers of brokers or coordinators. These brokers often lead social organizations or neighborhood commissions. The grassroots brokers are typically neighborhood residents or heads of large families. The positionality and work of each layer appear similar to what we observed in São Paulo. However, the internal dynamics of a party seem more cohesive in the case described by Dosek (2023). Further comparative research is needed to understand better the similarities and differences between mandates and equipo político.

Also, it is through *mandatos* that parties get territorially embedded. This is evident for local elections, but political mobilization for elections at all levels

must go to the territory to find voters. Traditionally, such capillary connections worked differently by party, and the Workers' Party (PT) had the most potent societal and territorial embeddedness (Keck 1992). This changed, however, as other parties recognized local councils, associations, churches, and other local institutions as key instruments for political mobilization. Therefore, these practices and repertories of mobilization tend to be quite generalized nowadays, and many combinations and migrations are possible.

Three short cases illustrate this situation. In the first, we found a chief of staff of a left-wing party who works to a centrist *mandato* because she "likes the group" and believes their work is progressive. In a second case, a councilor incorporated in his *mandato* a broker who worked for a representative who lost the election. The representative and the broker were affiliated to a different party from the councilor, but they were all centrists. In a third case, a chief of staff has been affiliated for 30 years to a left-wing party, but works for a centrist *mandato*. "Some day I need to disaffiliate," he said, "but I still have some friends there."

The Political Construction of a Constituency in the Territory

We have already understood what is a *mandato* and how it is structured and connected with political parties and the local Council. In this section, we show how *mandatos* relate to voters through the city's territory and how they contribute to building constituencies.

In 2020, we started to navigate the northern region of São Paulo (296 km², more than 2 million inhabitants) through the lens and practices of Antônio, a macrobroker: "So today, we'll visit this community that is dealing with a damaged playground that was recently built by contractors using budget amendments from our mandato. But they did a shitty job, and it's not safe for kids, the ground is already cracking, and the equipment is broken. It's going to be tough. I am friends with the housing association leader, but the PCC (organized crime organization) doesn't want us there, so it's an unstable situation. Also, the councilor said, 'Let it go,' because he has this relationship with the contractors, but I can't; I have a commitment with these people. Then, we are going to another neighborhood to collect some blankets donated by a family and bring them to another leader so she can distribute them to some other families in her community. (Antônio)

John (2011) named propinquities the patterns the spatial ontology of politics created through locations, distances, contiguities, and flows. Developing further, Marques (2017) reminds us that propinquities represent the crystallization of certain spatialities made through practices, including inherited (but

politically constructed) space and the tangible effects of political actions on space. Political actions, in turn, continuously reconstruct these locations, flows, contiguities, and distances. In our case, space is built in interaction with the spatial and sociopolitical configuration of *mandatos* and their actions and relations. In this sense, *mandatos* connect what seemed to be isolated parts: "And then we will meet two ladies from another neighbourhood. They are willing to put together a party in the street to celebrate Children's Day. I don't know them well. They were in touch with a colleague from our mandato who left to work in the USA. So, there is an empty spot I will try to fill in. I hope they like me, but I think they do; we have met before. Otherwise, they might go back connecting the broker from the next street, who works for that federal representative who was a singer, you know? I forgot her name" (Antônio).

The connections between localities would sometimes be made through geographical contiguities such as in "this is the church we are now trying to be in touch with"—he would say slowing down the car—"the former priest didn't like me for some reason. Now the priest has presented us to the community, and wéve even elected a participatory councilor for the local health unit; oh look, it´s right here," Antônio would say, pointing to a public building on my side of the road. The church's physical location, such as schools and other public facilities, tends to make building a political territory easier, as they create communities with trust ties surrounding them. As social movements scholars have shown, although organizations can be internally incoherent, they provide favorable conditions for diverse activists to initiate and strengthen ties in areas of common interest (Nicholls 2008). Along with possibilities, spatial locations can also create constraints and disincentives for specific actions, such as avoiding the church and its surrounding areas "because the previous priest didn't like us." In other moments, Antônio would connect places by moving artifacts around, such as the mentioned blankets, creating political space through fluxes and circulation.

Expanding a *mandato* means expanding its constituency. Each broker does this in their own way, based on their own inscription in the territory, spheres of sociopolitical life in which they participate and how they access and activate different repertoires of action (Tilly 2006)—whether from bureaucracies, social movements, churches, etc. This gives brokers specific competences and specialities, with effects on how a problem is constructed as public (instead of a favor) and how solutions are sought. Life trajectories embedded in territorial inscriptions give brokers the resources to deal with situations. For this reason, although these operations invariably go through formal instruments that we can call the legislative repertoire—such as bills, budget amendments, and petitions—they are not restricted to them. They can also be carried out through political mobilization repertoires linked to other areas of socio-

political life, such as social movements that put "the people on the streets" and organize forums to discuss relevant issues. The addition of other repertoires does not minimize the importance of the legislative ones. In fact, the legislative repertoire explains why well-established political leaders in participatory bodies, such as councils and movements, tie themselves to *mandatos*. We can see this through the lens of Antônio and Inês, both macrobrokers from Paulo's *mandato*.

Antônio joined the *mandato* as a journalist and gradually began identified with *political work*. As he is not a resident of the communities with which he works, he needs to determine whether "the group is willing to build a real relationship." He explains that he wants to be a channel for the group to vocalize their demands, which will be converted into problems to be solved through the *mandato*. However, as it requires effort and time, he expects that it will lead to a long-lasting relationship that, over time, will support the *mandato* to remain in power based on the votes of these people. Brokers want to be held accountable for their work, to continue to be demanded, and to be able to explain why they did or didn't address grievances. In a complementary formulation, he said: "I'm really honest straight away, so I don't waste my time, and they don't waste theirs. I explain how I work, what I can and what I can't, but that I'm going after it. And I want people to tell me what they want as well. You need to tell me what you need, help me, and I'll help you."

Because Antônio had a previous position as a bureaucrat in the housing department, he handles bureaucratic language well. He uses this skill to address issues with the Executive and communicate with people. In the WhatsApp groups, he creates communities dealing with specific issues, or on his Facebook page, he usually communicates by sharing official documents and communicating with public authorities to solve issues. His Facebook page is, therefore, full of stamps, signatures, and official symbols, eloquently portraying him as someone familiar with such repertory and able to mediate the relationships with the executive power (Figure 1).

Antônio also says that once the relationship is established, he "strengthens his leaders." The leaders would start operating as microbrokers, creating a more stable system for collecting and forwarding grievances of all kinds. So, how does one become a broker when you weren't one before? Antônio's answers speak for many others: "I started by participating in everything that happened in the area: public hearings, facility councils, […], everything there was, there I would be. I still do, but now I have started putting other leaders there and even helping them to be elected [in local councils]. That's how I started to meet local leaders and go into poorer neighborhoods. I got to know more families got involved with them… Poor people have much more demands, so keeping in touch is easy!"



Figure 1. Facebook posts by Antônio with copies of the letters to the Executive.
Source: Brokers' Facebook page.

It must be said that an essential part of these demands comes from the deficiency in service provision by the Executive branch in poorer regions. Therefore, although brokers and *mandatos* also operate in central and wealthier regions, *political work* is concentrated on the peripheries for two main reasons. The first one is the fact that Brazil's profound social inequality is also geographical. So focusing *political work* in the wealthiest part of the city would be inefficient since most voters are poor. Second, although there are people who speak on behalf of councilors and organize political meetings at times of campaigning in wealthier areas, they do not become professionalized. This makes them "supporters" of *mandatos* but not strictly brokers.

In one participatory meeting, Antônio met Inês. She works in Paulo's office and is a medical assistance technician. This profession gives her a busy schedule, but it also brings essential resources for her dedication to politics. On the top of that, she also coordinates a housing association (she prefers calling it that instead of movement), is a representative in at least eight participatory councils, and is a leader in the evangelical church she attends. These intense multitasking and multiple affiliations explain her entry the *mandato* as a microbroker and later transformation into a macrobroker.

Inês is not active in social media, but to show differences in approaches and repertories, we illustrate with the Facebook page of another macrobroker who shares her trajectory and intensely brings their traditional social movements to social media. Instead of forwarding official documents to his

groups, he would bring testimony of meetings with the Executive, also sustaining proximity to the Executive, but from the point of view of the mobilization of his political work. This is what his Facebook page looks like (Figure 2).

Thinking it would help her in the fight for housing, Inês applied for the participatory council in her region and "by luck," as she describes it, she was elected. It wasn't long before she began to be contacted by brokers operating in the area, illustrating a common way macrobrokers approach microbrokers: "Then I joined the participatory council of Vila Rosa as the best-voted woman in the region. Almost 500 votes (…) When it was Monday afternoon, my phone started ringing. "It was people from various parties. Many people called me, congratulating me and saying they knew my work. How could they know my work if I hadn't even worked in the area yet? Then you see how political co-optation begins in the business, 'one more for us to manipulate in politics', they must have thought (…). Antônio was one of them (…). But then later, I realized I could use the *mandato* to advise us, strengthen and bring power to what we are trying to achieve here."

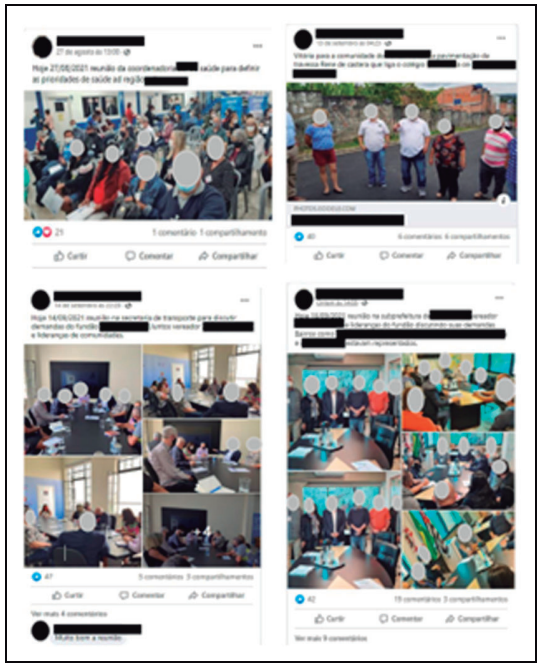


Figure 2. Broker's Facebook posts presenting meetings and people who attended.
Source: Brokers' Facebook page.

Among other interesting things, Inês' statement combines an intense desire for autonomy with an interest in scaling mobilization. It also inverts the direction of support: it is the *mandato* that "advises" or enhances the territorial work that is already done, not vice versa. This creates numerous points of tension, including who gets the credit for any achievements; as Inês summarizes, "There's a lot we do, and the councilor puts it on his account." Inês took a while to choose a councilor to be linked to because she feared losing decision-making autonomy.

Concerning autonomy, brokers have more power in these vertical relationships than is usually considered, since changes throughout incumbency in the capillary structure of *mandatos* reconstruct political territories, with electoral consequences. Brokers move in and out of a *mandato* for interpersonal reasons (differences of opinion and expectations, fights) and financial disagreements (better payment elsewhere). When brokers move around to another *mandato*, they most likely take their networks and relationships with them—unless people are unsatisfied with their *political work*. As a result, they move the influence over their territories (and their votes) to the new *mandato*. This was exemplified in Antônio's previous quote when he feared another broker would replace his colleague who left the *mandato*. This happens somewhat frequently in a scenario of intense political competition, leading councilors to lose influence over territories between elections, and therefore not creating a stable informal district. Therefore, while councilors are the ones about whom political mobilization is made, and the relationships are not symmetric, brokers have more autonomy than the literature has given them credit for.

Therefore, brokerage structures do not result in an automatic and complete alignment of strategies within the *mandato*. On the contrary, macro- and microbrokers resist being controlled. Sometimes, they don't even want to be called "political advisors" as it is attached to a clientelist interpretation of politics and try to maintain their links with their groups and localities, even if in contradiction to the councilors' decisions and guidelines. As we saw in Antônio's words early in this section, "the councilor said 'let it go' (…), but I just can't; I commit with this people." This may cause important conflicts as will be explored in the next section, with analytical consequences for the study of representation.

Representation on the Ground, Incongruences, and Alignments

An essential social housing project would be built in the community of microbroker Capitão, linked to councilor Paulo through macrobroker Antônio. This was an area of precarious houses, which would be transformed into a housing

project, using a public–private partnership format. This would involve the eviction of the people who lived in the area and the construction of the new units, but it was not clear if the new units would reallocate the evicted families. The local government demolished the shacks erected in the plot but failed to organize a meeting to explain the project to the residents and deal with what would happen to them after the eviction. Councilor Paulo saw this as an opportunity to build stronger ties with the community, so he asked Antônio to organize an event with Executive representatives, housing movements, and the residents themselves. In addition to Antônio and Capitão, Inês also attended the event.

Inês and Capitão made speeches during the event that sought to *engage people* but in opposite directions. First, over the microphone, quite assertively, Capitão demanded that the Executive should allocate the removed residents in the project and sought to engage residents to manifest themselves in the same direction. Then Inês spoke, urging that members of the housing movement she coordinates, based not so far from there and registered for social housing long before, should be prioritized in the new units, which probably would lead to no space for the residents of the demolished shacks. Councilor *Paulo*, in turn, has strong ties to the real estate developers in the city. Antônio, on his side, tried to neutralize the conflict: "I had to roll over later to calm the residents (…) I stayed afterwards talking to them alone."

Each broker nurtures bonds that are usually functional to the *mandato*, but sometimes they are mutually irreconcilable. Taking this case into consideration, who should the representative choose to represent? People that were already living in the area? The housing movement? Territories were being claimed, as we can see through the lens of collective everyday practices. In this case, however, we are dealing with one of the many situations in which they can also contradict the *mandatos'* aim of creating a stable constituency. After all, representation is not a fixed form (Saward 2010).

Political representation has widely been described from a normative point of view that prevents us from seeing how it unfolds in time and space. To better understand the situation, maybe we could start considering that we are facing—as in many other interactions—a situation in which intermediaries are really trying to represent their constituencies, and not deviating from them as sometimes it is sustained.

In democratic regimes, Pitkin (1967) classically delineated authorization, accountability, and responsiveness as the core components of representation, a framework that subsequent discussions have expanded upon with significant analytical consequences. However, as noted earlier regarding legislative institutions and their societal context, the literature on representation has often automatically linked it solely to the state apparatus, overlooking its inherently relational and procedural nature. While other discussions have yet to fully

integrate such arguments, the so-called representative turn has recognized the analytical limitations of how the concept has been used so far (Saward 2010; Urbinati and Warren 2008).

Gurza Lavalle and Isunza Vera (2011) contend that throughout much of the 20th century, theoretical conceptions of representation and the structures of representative government were so closely intertwined that they hindered the advancement of political theory. Consequently, the discourse surrounding the concept of representation, as formulated by Pitkin, is surprisingly recent, despite the abundance of studies on governing rules, their actors, and their impacts within the field. This is, at least in part, why we can understand that voting has been studied as the only mechanism of authorization. If brokers are not themselves elected, they are seen as a deviation in the middle of the path, creating perverse accountability (Stokes 2005).

In the story presented above, brokers act as representatives of specific interests within particular groups, often deeply rooted in territorial contexts, especially in urban settings where claims tend to be localized. Given the size of the city, the structure of electoral rules, and deficiencies in public policy provisions, these interests may not receive adequate attention otherwise. This highlights that representation is not solely tied to the state apparatus but is also a relational practice. It's important to acknowledge that whenever someone speaks on behalf of others, authorized by mechanisms beyond mere voting (such as trust), a relationship of representation is established (Zaremberg, Gurza Lavalle and Guarneros-Meza 2017). To provide a thorough analytical treatment of brokers as representatives themselves, it's essential to consider the brokers' own interests. Unfortunately, this aspect has often been viewed with skepticism.

Unlike Legislative and Comparative Studies, debates in democratic theory have analyzed various types of intermediation between the State and citizens, as a way for intermediaries to *speak for citizens* even without formal authorization (Peruzzotti 2012; Von Liers and Piper 2014; Wheeler 2014). However, "speaking for," a widely accepted notion to define what an intermediary does, keeps the record of responsiveness/accountability as a congruence. In this sense, this fails to fully capture what intermediaries do. They generally do not *speak for* someone but are in a permanent process of negotiating identities and interests. Considering the multiple positionalities as leaders, staff, bureaucrats, etc. when speaking for someone, from which group is the broker representing?

Brokers' self-interested actions are considered, but usually with smaller analytical relevance. As we saw in Section 1, "self-interested actions," "dual agency," "independent position," and "room for maneuver" are adjectives for empirical evidence of a topic that we have not yet satisfactorily dealt with theoretically: the representative status of brokers. These actors have

received little attention as representatives, so their conflicts, dilemmas, and identities have been analyzed independently of the conflicts arising from authorization and responsiveness mechanisms. Intermediating, being in the middle, therefore, means simultaneously representing the legislator (or State) to the population and representing the population to the legislator (or State). If we apply Pitkin's concept to them, according to which they "act in the best interests of others in a way that is responsive to them," taking multiple and simultaneous positions into account is not difficult to imagine due to the same components of independence and responsiveness, moments when the interests of the two ends collide. The *mandato* is an analytical interesting category because it sheds light on such entanglements.

In the context of *mandatos*, the overarching goal is to create, maintain, and expand political support for a politician and, in doing so, expand constituencies. For councilors, achieving this goal enhances their chances of reelection or advancement to higher political positions and enables them to advocate for policies and ideas they support in broader areas of the city. Similarly, for brokers, enlarging constituencies through enlarging their networks not only improves their chances of keeping their jobs (and climbing the career ladder) but also enables them to support their communities and interest groups.

Brokers can expand their networks by simultaneously participating in associations and movements outside the legislative structure, such as housing movements and participatory councils. *Mandatos* benefit collectively when their brokers are embedded in various community groups and territories, and such political actors are valued for that feature. Groups in society also benefit from such political mobilization work since they gain additional channels to address their grievances. The bigger the network, the better the chances that fewer groups or neighborhoods are left behind. Such perception resonates with arguments made by Ostrom (1990), who focused on how communities manage common pool resources through collective action; Tilly (2006), who emphasized the role of social networks, opportunities, and mobilizing structures in shaping collective action dynamics and outcomes; and Doug McAdam (1982), who has highlighted the interplay between political opportunities, mobilizing structures, and framing processes in the emergence and development of social movements.

However, such dynamic creates a paradox. The more societal groups and territories are represented within a *mandato*, and the more deeply entrenched brokers are in various spheres, the more challenging it becomes to deliver policies and address grievances effectively. Brokers may prioritize competing interests and agendas, making consensus-building and policy implementation more challenging within a *mandato* to the point that voters' grievances might not even be addressed.

Such a paradox underscores the inherent tension within the representational relationship. If viewed solely through the lens of congruence and authorization via voting, these intricate dynamics would likely remain overlooked. Embracing a broader framework of representation, one that extends beyond the confines of the government apparatus, necessitates adopting a descriptive approach—rather than a normative one—to comprehend how this relationship unfolds at each stage of the intermediation chain. Taking this descriptive approach allows for an empirical analysis of the development of these relationships in practice, free from the imposition of norms or biases regarding their evolution. This approach enhances our understanding of the challenges and opportunities *mandatos* encounter in forming and representing their constituencies, as well as the complexities involved in reconciling the diverse and sometimes conflicting interests of communities and social groups in democratic contexts. As a theoretical implication, it also brings to the front a question Urbinati (2006) has already made about what are the conditions under which representation *is* democratic—that is, a mode of political participation that can activate a variety of forms of citizen control and oversight.

Conclusion

This article presented the existence and functioning of *mandatos* and suggested a framework to understand them through representation as practices that unfold in time and space. The concept of *mandato* in Brazil brings to the debate the possibility of discussing mid-level structures that contentiously bridge formal institutions, parties, and politics on the ground of local communities, actively building constituencies. As we have presented, *mandatos* are sets of interconnected actors that actively operate to produce political support to a politician mobilizing formal and informal institutions and practices in the territories of the city. Although *mandatos* incorporate (macro and micro) brokers as a crucial feature, their dynamics is bigger, more incongruent, and contentious than just the sum of brokers and politicians. They channel various forms of distributive or programmatic politics, depending on the context.

In analytical terms, *mandatos* allow us to see representation as a process, not only attached to institutions. Such process happens between elected representatives and citizens, but also between multiple representatives and multiple voters. How *mandatos* are created and operate leads us to look for an alternative grammar for representation. *Mandatos* bring to the forefront multiple representatives operating inside the same group, making different claims that cannot be understood only through the lens of the vote as a mode of authorization to the elected in relation to the represented. Also, it cannot be

understood solely through formal attributes of legislators or electoral rules, since it entails processes and practices in the city's territory.

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Notes

1. *"Não sou nada sem minhas lideranças"; "Eu fortaleço minhas lideranças"*
2. In São Paulo, although one very powerful criminal organization (PCC) is present in most poor neighborhoods, territorial control is not part of their strategy, so coercion is not relevant in elections—https://www.bbc.com/portuguese/articles/cd6y9gey6q3o. In other Brazilian contexts were criminal organizations such as *militias* territorially control poor neighborhoods, such as in Rio de Janeiro, coercion is a relevant practice (Wheeler, 2014).

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